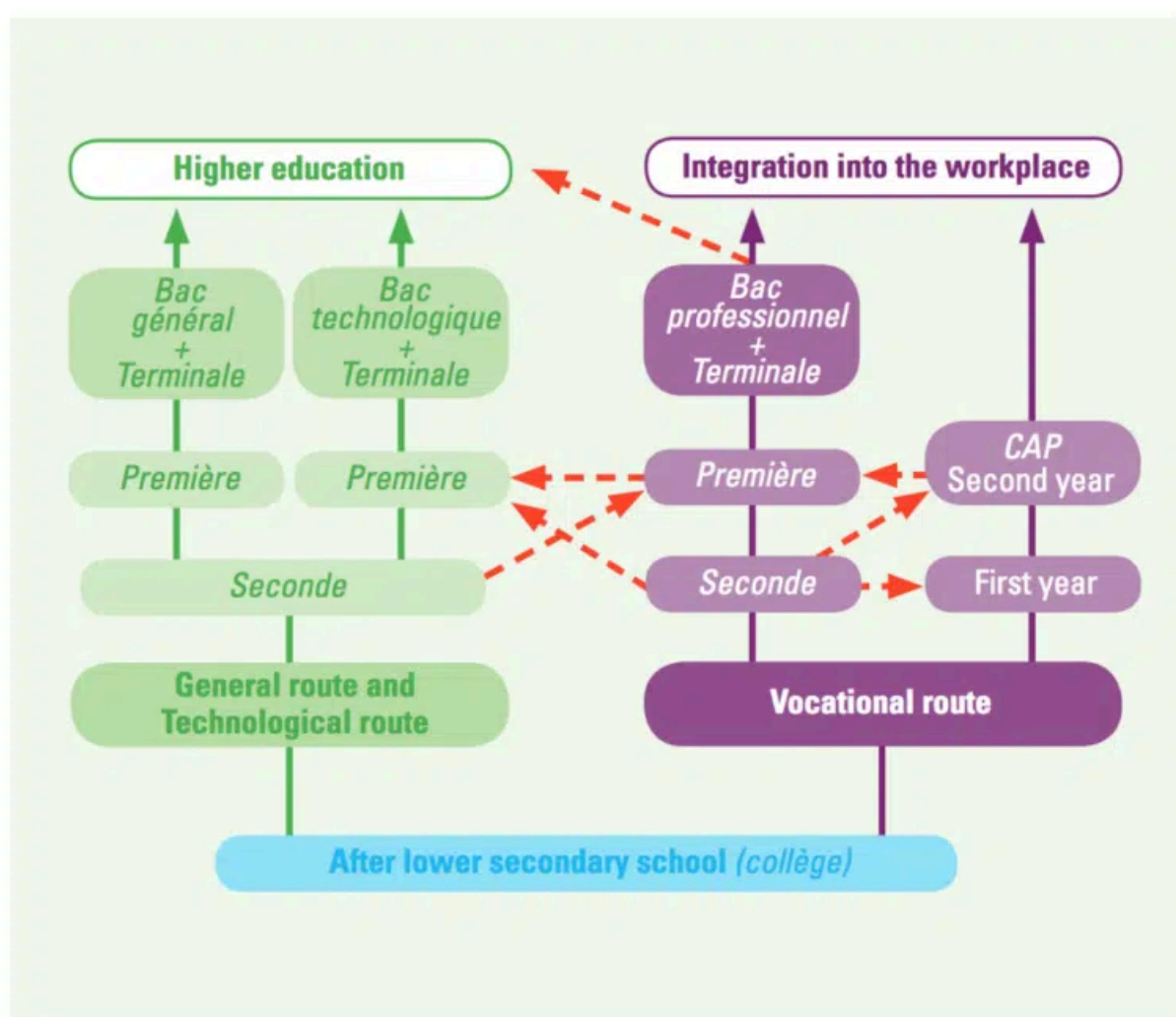


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[< Previous Topic](#)[Next Topic >](#)

B2. Primary, Middle and Secondary School Education



In France, children must attend school from the ages of 6 to 16; this obligation covers both primary school and the first four years of secondary education (*collège*).

Education for children is divided into three stages:

- Primary school (*école élémentaire*), for children aged 6 to 11.
- Middle school (*collège*), for children aged 11 to 15.
- Secondary school (*lycée*), for children aged 16 for three years. The first year is *la seconde*, the second is *la première* and the third is *la terminale*. During *la première*, students take three compulsory specialist subjects and then narrow down to two in their final year. This decision is then reflected in the particular exams they go on to take to complete their high school education.

The *lycée* prepares students to take the baccalaureate exam (*baccalauréat* or less formally, *le bac*), which is equivalent to British A-levels. Obtaining a *baccalauréat* diploma allows students to progress to higher education or to enter a profession. Most students take this exam to obtain a *bac* but there are also other diplomas available for students who want to pursue vocational studies leading to a job in a certain field. Please see **SECTION D** for more on the three streams (*général, technologique, and professionnel*) and diplomas available to students at *lycées*.

Preparatory Classes

Also delivered through high schools are preparatory classes for students aiming to obtain certain post-secondary certificates, diplomas and degrees and/or hoping to be admitted to a certain institution. These include:

- CPGEs (*Classes préparatoires aux grandes écoles*): two-year preparatory classes for students wanting to be admitted to France's exclusive *grandes écoles* and
- Classes in preparation for the national *Brevet de technicien supérieur* (BTS) certificate which is a two-year senior technician certificate considered a national diploma of higher education in France.

As well as French public schools, there are also roughly 100 international schools that offer schooling in English and an English curriculum and a network of almost 10,000 private schools, most which are religiously affiliated, which cater to nearly 20% of school-aged children.

[◀ Previous Topic](#)

[Back to Lesson](#)

[Next Topic ▶](#)